the deepest secret nobody knows

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/58933465.

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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by Fangirl_on_a_bicycle

Summary

Catra loves Adora.

Once upon a time, it was a shameful secret Catra couldn't even admit to herself. Now half of Etheria knows.

But professing your feelings when you both might die is one thing. Doing it day after day is another.

Vulnerability is terrifying.

Catra learns how to push past her fear and express her feelings to Adora.

(Rated mature because sex is one way to show your feelings for someone.)

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Catra loves Adora.

Once upon a time, it was a shameful secret Catra couldn't even admit to herself. Now half of Etheria knows.

But professing your feelings when you both might die is one thing. Doing it day after day is another.

Vulnerability is terrifying.

Adora will never intentionally hurt her. Adora loves her just as much as she loves Adora. Despite everything Catra's done, Adora came back for her, and Adora's love for her saved the universe.

But still hiding next to Catra's heart is the part of her that knows: love is dangerous. People you love can leave you. People you love can be taken from you. People you love can hurt you, or be used by someone else to hurt you. People you love can use that love against you. A hard mask, a wall of armor around your heart, those will protect you.

Baring her heart to someone gives them the opportunity to hurt her. Maybe it would be better to wrap it in barbed wire and keep everyone out.

But always protecting her heart from hurt means never letting anyone in, either. It means hurting other people when they try to care about her. Catra has already tried that–and it caused more pain than anything in her life ever has. The barbed wire she'd wrapped around her heart cut her, too.

She's not going to make that mistake again.

Adora needs to know that Catra loves her. Adora is so good at loving Catra, even on days she struggles to accept it. She needs to return it. She needs Adora to know, to never doubt Catra's love.

Because Perfuma was right: it's worth it. Every day she wakes up to Adora next to her, every day Adora smiles at her and kisses her,

every day they fall asleep together; and it is everything Catra has ever wanted. And that is worth doing every impossible thing.

Simple physical affection is the easiest, by far. Leaning on each other while sitting. Cuddling in bed. Holding hands. Sitting in Adora's lap. Brushing her tail against her. Letting Adora pet her and scritch behind her ears, and rewarding Adora with a purr. Even the rough-housing and play-wrestling are affectionate, just as they always were.

She can even do a lot of it around other people–Glimmer and Bow especially, since they're just as touchy these days. Some of them are things Catra and Adora have done since they were children, even into their teen years when both of them wondered to themselves if it meant anything more.

Also, the kiss at the Heart opened the floodgates and now they can't stop kissing all the time. Cheek kisses in front of people, quick kisses coming and going, long lingering kisses while alone.

Showing Adora love through touch and kisses, that's as easy as breathing.

Giving Adora orgasms is merely a more intense physical affection, and therefore also easy. If anything it feels selfish, because the looks on Adora's face, the sound of Adora crying out her name, the sensation of Adora squeezing down on her fingers, her hands in Catra's hair clenched so hard they're shaking–well, who wouldn't be proud of that?

Pleasing Adora until she can barely walk and her voice is rough from shouting–Catra enjoys it at least as much as Adora does. She loves covering Adora's body with kisses and bite marks, the scent of her arousal so strong Catra's drunk on it, her mouth watering, her face between Adora's thighs. She loves knowing what drives Adora insane with wanting, when to be soft and when to be

sharp, what makes her whine with impatience, when to say sweet things and when to tease her, what makes Adora come again and again and again. She loves expressing her love for Adora on every part of Adora's body.

Letting Adora return the favor is a little trickier. There are days it's difficult to let go enough, and days that asking for what she wants can be a struggle. But Adora wants to please her, too; and loving Adora means letting her do it.

Sometimes Catra has to keep part of her mask on–she's sharp in the way she asks for things, insists on being in charge, only lets Adora please her on her own terms. It only works because Adora can see through Catra's mask, though. (And Adora has admitted she likes to be told what to do, sometimes; so it's still a way of pleasing Adora.)

Some days it's easier, though. On a good day she can just be soft and lose herself in Adora's touch, let Adora overwhelm her, moan Adora's name. Some days it's easy to be wanted, to be desired; and Adora's hands and mouth know Catra's body better than anyone ever has or ever will. Giving herself to Adora to be loved and purring with satisfaction in her arms when it's over is another way of loving her.

Helping Adora can be hard, for two reasons: One is that Adora herself struggles to allow people to do anything for her and she rarely asks for help. Catra can at least understand that, since they're both working on it.

The other reason is that people might notice when you do romantic gestures for your partner, and just the knowing smiles are enough to make Catra's face heat with embarrassment.

It's one thing to remind Adora to stop what she's doing and eat at mealtimes. It's another thing to go to the kitchen and ask the staff

to bring dinner to their bedroom so they can still eat together when Adora's absorbed in a task. And it's yet another thing to ask the kitchen ahead of time for a picnic basket with some of Adora's favorites in it, to pull Adora away from working and surprise her with a romantic meal to themselves outdoors in the gardens of Bright Moon.

And yes, Bow caught her walking through the castle with the basket and wouldn't shut up about how cute it was until Catra threatened to cut him if he didn't knock it off. Worth it, though; to see the delight on Adora's face when she saw what was in the basket. Not to mention all the kisses and cuddling out in the gardens. But helping Adora take care of herself and eat and rest, that's a loving thing to do.

Talking about feelings, though.

Sometimes, Catra thinks she'd rather die.

But also, she'd do anything for Adora-even die.

The first two times that Catra poured her heart out to Adora, Catra thought she might die:

Her apology shouted over the comm from Prime's ship, while trying to save Adora's life.

Her confession of love at the Heart, while begging Adora to stay.

And now universe is saved, and both of them are as safe as anyone ever can be, and Catra has to convince the scared and hurt parts of herself that the danger is over, and she still needs to tell Adora how she feels every day for the rest of their lives.

The next time Catra apologizes to Adora, it's the middle of the night and Catra can barely get the words out, sobbing into Adora's

shoulder and apologizing for so many of the ways she's hurt Adora, and eventually it feels a bit less like bleeding to death and a bit more like being drained of some poison–painful, but necessary.

(She knows Adora's already forgiven her. That's not the point.)

Telling Adora she loves her is easier to do when hidden in sarcasm: "You're such an idiot."

Adora understands her ("Yeah, I know–"), but still.

It's important to push through all the armor and scars around her heart and just say it.

She says it with Adora spooned up behind her in the dark, kissing Adora's hand: "I love you so much." She says it into Adora's neck, when both of them are sweaty and breathless and satisfied: "Fuck, I love you." She says it every time Adora says it first, even if she has to close her eyes or look away against the intensity of Adora's gaze: "I love you, too."

One day in a moment of bravery (and also because Adora is away from Bright Moon for the day, and Catra misses her) she writes it down, scribbling out all her feelings before she can overthink them or regret it. She nearly burns the pages when she's done, unable to even bring herself to reread them. Instead she leaves them on Adora's desk and then stays out of their bedroom until Adora comes home, and Catra nearly bolts from the castle when Adora walks toward their bedroom after dinner. But instead Catra hovers in the doorway with her heart in her throat and watches Adora find the letter and start reading it and sit down. When she's done and she looks up at Catra she's openly weeping, and Catra runs into her arms.

It gets easier with practice. She mumbles it into kisses before they fall asleep. She pants it out when Adora's hands are on her. She whispers it into Adora's ear at dinner just to make her blush in front of their friends.

I love you, I love you, I love you.

One day Catra realizes it feels like safety, not danger. It’s not frightening to be vulnerable with Adora because Adora already knows and loves every part of her. It’s safe to give her naked and unguarded heart to Adora because she’s had it the whole time.

And because Adora gave Catra her heart ages ago. It's always been there, inside of her own.

End Notes

Listen: the "You're such an idiot"/"Yeah, I know!" in Save the Cat was actually their first love confession and I will fight you on this.

Title is stolen from an e e cummings poem:

i carry your heart with me(i carry it in
my heart)i am never without it(anywhere
i go you go,my dear;and whatever is done
by only me is your doing,my darling)
i fear
no fate(for you are my fate,my sweet)i want
no world(for beautiful you are my world,my true)
and it’s you are whatever a moon has always meant
and whatever a sun will always sing is you

here is the deepest secret nobody knows
(here is the root of the root and the bud of the bud
and the sky of the sky of a tree called life;which grows
higher than soul can hope or mind can hide)
and this is the wonder that's keeping the stars apart

i carry your heart(i carry it in my heart)

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